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Policy tags for 5G network function inconsistency detection and reconciliation

Abstract

Systems and methods for providing policy tags to detect and reconcile inconsistencies between a network function (NF) producer and an NF consumer are provided herein. In an example, a system includes instructions for a NF producer to establish a first state with an NF consumer, where the NF producer and the NF consumer are in a 5G network, generate a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, and store the first policy tag as the latest stored policy tag. The latest policy tag is then transmitted in subsequent signaling from/to the NF consumer and signaling including the latest received policy tag is received from the NF consumer. A validation process is then performed with the latest received policy tag from the NF consumer and the communication is processed based on the validation process of the received policy tag.

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) Various embodiments of the present technology generally relate to network function communication within 5G networks. More specifically, embodiments of the present technology relate to systems and methods for providing detecting an inconsistency in shared stated data between two or more network functions (NFs) within a 5G network and reconciling the inconsistency.

BACKGROUND

(2) In the realm of 5G networks, N7 policy evaluation and decision at the Policy Control Function (PCF) play a pivotal role in ensuring efficient and dynamic network management. N7 represents a reference point in the 5G architecture, specifically designed for communication between the PCF and the Session Management Function (SMF). The PCF is responsible for enforcing policies related to quality of service, network slicing, and user authentication. N7 policy evaluation involves the examination of these policies in real-time, considering factors such as network congestion, user demands, and application requirements. The PCF's decision-making process at the N7 level involves dynamically adapting policies to optimize resource allocation, enhance user experience, and maintain the overall integrity of the 5G network. This capability is crucial for delivering on the promises of low-latency, high-speed connectivity, and personalized services in the era of 5G communications. As technology continues to evolve, the N7 policy evaluation and decision mechanisms at the PCF will remain instrumental in shaping the efficiency and performance of 5G networks.

(3) Currently, to aid in efficient session establishment within the 5G network, the PCF interacts with the SMF. Interactions between the SMF and the PCF are pivotal for orchestrating seamless and optimized user experiences. The SMF takes the lead in session management, handling tasks such as authentication, mobility management, and IP address assignment. Concurrently, the SMF collaborates closely with the PCF to leverage policy information that shapes the characteristics of the user session. The PCF, as the key component for policy control, provides the SMF with real-time policy decisions based on factors like Quality of Service (QoS) requirements, network conditions, and service-level agreements. This interaction ensures that the policies governing aspects such as data prioritization, bandwidth allocation, and application-specific treatment are effectively enforced throughout the user session. Through this dynamic collaboration, the SMF and PCF collectively contribute to the delivery of enhanced 5G services, allowing for adaptive, policy-driven control over network resources to meet the diverse needs of users and applications.

(4) Disruptions, however, may arise leading to the PCF and SMF operating at inconsistent states. As those skilled in the art readily appreciate, operating at an inconsistent state between the PCF and the SMF may lead to disruptions in network performance and user experience. An inconsistent state may result from communication or signaling delays or failures between these key network functions, leading to misalignments in policy enforcement and session management. This miscoordination can trigger discrepancies in QoS, hinder the proper implementation of network slicing, and impact the allocation of resources. Users may experience fluctuations in data speeds, dropped connections, denials, or delays in accessing services. It is imperative for 5G network operators to address and mitigate these issues promptly, as a harmonized and synchronized operation between the PCF and SMF is essential for delivering the promised benefits of 5G, such as low latency, high data rates, and efficient resource utilization.

(5) Currently techniques and systems, however, only allow for reactive detection of inconsistencies between the PCF and SMF. As such, inconsistencies are only detected after they have already occurred and thus often lead to emerging issues. Accordingly, there exists a need for improved signaling mechanisms, such as the policy tags and related functions provided herein, that can provide proactive inconsistency detection and reconciliation between network functions (NFs) within the 5G network. In other words, the policy tags and related functions provided herein can eliminate implicit reactive detection and provide proactive inconsistency detection and reconciliation in many cases.

(6) The information provided in this section is presented as background information and serves only to assist in any understanding of the present disclosure. No determination has been made and no assertion is made as to whether any of the above might be applicable as prior art with regard to the present disclosure.

(7) Overview

(8) Technology is disclosed herein for systems and techniques for providing policy tags, and their related functions, to detect and reconcile network function inconsistencies. In particular, policy tags are provided herein for detecting inconsistencies between a NF producer and a NF consumer, such as between the PCF and the SMF. To detect inconsistencies, a policy tag is generated by a NF producer to indicate a current state of operation when communicating with a NF consumer. When the NF consumer receives a policy tag from the NF producer, the NF consumer stores the policy tag. In subsequent communications between the NF producer and the NF consumer, a most recent policy tag is identified and provided to the corresponding NF. For example, when sending an update request to a PCF, the SMF may include a most recent policy tag to indicate its current state. When the PCF receives the update request, the PCF identifies the most recent policy tag and determines its own most recent policy tag (e.g., the policy tag the PCF stored prior to receiving the update request). The PCF then compares the two policy tags to determine if the two NFs are operating according to consistent states.

(9) If a NF producer determines that the two NFs are operating according to a consistent state, then

the NF producer continues with the update request. If the NF producer, however, determines that the two NFs are operating according to inconsistent states, then the NF producer determines an inconsistency. As will be described in greater detail below, when the NF producer determines an inconsistency, the NF producer determines an appropriate reconciliation process based on the type of inconsistency and current operational configuration of the NFs. Once the appropriate reconciliation process is identified, the NF producer performs the identified reconciliation process and the two NFs are returned to operating on consistent states.

(10) This Overview is provided to introduce a selection of concepts in a simplified form that are further described below in the Detailed Description. It may be understood that this Overview is not intended to identify key features or essential features of the claimed subject matter, nor is it intended to be used to limit the scope of the claimed subject matter.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The accompanying drawings, which are incorporated into and constitute a part of this specification, illustrate one or more certain aspects and, together with the description of the example, serve to explain the principles and implementations of the certain examples.

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates an example operational environment for a 5G network in which one or more features of a policy tag process can be implemented, according to an embodiment herein;

(3) FIG. 2 illustrates an example SMF-PCF inconsistency scenario, according to an embodiment herein;

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates another example SMF-PCF inconsistency scenario involving multiple PCFs, according to an embodiment herein;

(5) FIG. 4 illustrates an operational scenario illustrating use of policy tags between an NF producer and an NF consumer, according to an embodiment herein;

(6) FIG. 5 illustrates an example policy tag process, in particular, a process for proactively detecting and reconciling inconsistencies between two or more NFs using policy tags, according to an embodiment herein;

(7) FIG. 6 illustrates an operational scenario illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags, according to an embodiment herein;

(8) FIG. 7 illustrates another operational scenario illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags, according to an embodiment herein;

(9) FIG. 8 illustrates an operational scenario illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs, according to an embodiment herein;

(10) FIG. 9 illustrates another operational scenario illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs, according to an embodiment herein;

(11) FIG. 10 illustrates another operational scenario illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs, according to an embodiment herein; and

(12) FIG. 11 shows an example computing device suitable for policy tags and their related functions, according to an embodiment herein.

(13) Some components or operations may be separated into different blocks or combined into a single block for the purposes of discussion of some of the embodiments of the present technology. Moreover, while the technology is amenable to various modifications and alternative forms, specific embodiments have been shown by way of example in the drawings and are described in detail below. The intention, however, is not to limit the technology to the particular embodiments described. On the contrary, the technology is intended to cover all modifications, equivalents, and alternatives falling within the scope of the technology as defined by the appended claims.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(14) The advent of 5G technology represents a paradigm shift in the realm of telecommunications, promising unprecedented advancements in connectivity, speed, and reliability. Unlike its predecessors, 5G is characterized not only by enhanced data rates but also by low latency, massive device connectivity, and the ability to support diverse applications, ranging from augmented reality to the Internet of Things (IoT). At the heart of the 5G architecture is the Service-Based Architecture (SBA), which fundamentally transforms the way network functions operate. In the 5G ecosystem, various network functions (NFs) are modularized, each serving specific roles in delivering end-to-end services. These NFs, including the Session Management Function (SMF), Policy Control Function (PCF), User Plane Function (UPF), and others, are interconnected through standardized interfaces, allowing for a more dynamic, scalable, and flexible network. The SBA enables these NFs to act as producers and consumers of services, fostering a modular and interoperable environment where services are orchestrated seamlessly to meet the diverse needs of users and applications. This architectural evolution is pivotal in realizing the full potential of 5G networks and accommodating the demands of an increasingly connected and data-driven world.

(15) However, despite the promise of 5G's advanced capabilities, the presence of inconsistencies between NFs can significantly undermine the performance and reliability of the network. In a 5G ecosystem where NFs operate collaboratively, any misalignment or inconsistency in communication between these functions may result in suboptimal service delivery. Issues such as misconfigured policies, conflicting QoS parameters, or delays in data transmission between functions can lead to service disruptions, degraded user experiences, and compromised network efficiency. For instance, if the SMF fails to synchronize seamlessly with the PCF, it may lead to discrepancies in policy enforcement, affecting crucial aspects like traffic steering and resource allocation. The interconnected nature of these NFs demands a harmonized operation, and any inconsistencies introduce vulnerabilities that can impede the seamless connectivity and advanced functionalities promised by 5G technology.

(16) One area in which inconsistencies adversely impact the functionality of 5G technology is communication between the SMF and PCF. Inconsistencies between the SMF and the PCF can have profound consequences on the 5G network and a user's experience within the 5G network. For example, when SMF-PCF inconsistencies occur, critical policies governing QoS, network slicing, and user authentication may not be uniformly enforced, leading to variations in service delivery. That is, if the SMF and PCF fail to communicate seamlessly, it may result in inaccuracies in policy decisions, impacting data prioritization, bandwidth allocation, and overall traffic management. Inconsistent enforcement of policies may disrupt the promised low-latency communication, compromise user data security, and hinder the efficient utilization of network resources. Furthermore, these discrepancies can pose challenges in implementing dynamic services and adapting to changing network conditions.

(17) Adding another layer of complexity to the challenges posed by SMF-PCF inconsistencies is the fact that the PCF, in its current design, often lacks the capability to proactively detect such inconsistencies. The PCF relies heavily on the information provided by various NFs, including the SMF, and inconsistencies may arise due to factors such as communication delays, configuration errors, or unforeseen network events. The reactive nature of inconsistency detection in the PCF can result in delayed responses to emerging issues, leaving the network vulnerable to disruptions. As a consequence, potential inconsistencies may only be identified when they manifest as operational problems or user experience issues, making it challenging to implement preemptive measures. Establishing mechanisms for more proactive monitoring, early detection, and automated resolution of inconsistencies between the SMF and PCF is crucial for enhancing the resilience and reliability of 5G networks in the face of dynamic and evolving communication environments.

(18) To allow for proactive inconsistency detection between the PCF and SMF, example policy tags and their related functions are provided herein. The policy tags are generated by a NF producer to indicate the current state of operation. A state of operation for a network function, such as the PCF

or SMF, encompasses the specific configuration, resource allocation, and rule sets that dictate its current mode of functionality within the broader network ecosystem. Thus, when communicating with a NF consumer, a NF producer generates and provides a policy tag to indicate the NF producer's current operating state. For example, the NF producer may receive a request from an NF consumer to establish a session. The session request may include state data for the session. Responsive to receiving the session request, the NF producer generates a policy tag for the session and stores the policy tag along with the state data for the session. The NF producer also transmits the policy tag to the NF consumer for the NF consumer to store and use in future communications. Thus, when the NF consumer communicates with the NF producer at a future time, the NF consumer provides the stored policy tag along with its request or response, thereby providing information as to its current operating state.

(19) Carrying forward, whenever there is an update in state by either the NF consumer or the NF producer, a new policy tag is generated and used for subsequent communications. In this manner, each NF can provide information on its current state to its NF counterpart, thereby allowing for identification of inconsistencies. By identifying inconsistencies before implementing a new operating state, one or more reconciliation methods can be performed to rectify the inconsistency. For example, when the NF producer receives the policy tag from the NF consumer, the NF producer compares that policy tag against a respective stored policy tag. If the received policy tag matches the respective stored policy tag, the NF producer validates that both NFs are operating at the same state. If, however, the NF producer determines that the policy tag received from the NF consumer does not match the respective stored policy tag, then the NF producer identifies the inconsistency between the two NFs and can determine an appropriate reconciliation method. A reconciliation method may be determined by the NF producer based on a type of conflict and operation configuration. Example reconciliation methods include last-update-wins, termination of the session and re-establishment of a new session, merging of the session records, re-synchronization of session states, and rebuilding of the session state. Each of these types or reconciliation methods will be described in greater detail below.

(20) The policy tags and related functions provided herein allow for timely identification of inconsistencies between NFs. Timely identification of inconsistencies between these functions is essential to prevent potential disruptions, enhance network reliability, and optimize resource utilization. The proactive detection provided by policy tags allows network operators to address discrepancies before they escalate into critical issues, ensuring that policies are applied consistently across sessions. As such, policy tags and their related functions not only safeguard the integrity of service delivery but also promote the effective implementation of QoS parameters, enabling 5G networks to meet the diverse and evolving needs of users and applications. In summary, policy tags provide for proactive detection and reconciliation of inconsistencies between PCF and SMF, thereby maintaining a resilient and high-performing 5G network.

(21) It should be appreciated that while the following discussion involves the NF producer and NF consumer being one of the PCF and the SMF, the policy tag and its related functions are equally applicable for other NFs. However, for ease of discussion the example policy tags provided herein are described in the context of the N7 level communication between the PCF and the SMF.

(22) Turning now to the Figures, FIG. 1 illustrates an example operational environment for a 5G network **100** in which one or more features of a policy tag process can be implemented, according to an embodiment herein. The example 5G network **100** is a 5G core (5GC) cellular network implementing 3GPP (3rd Generation Partnership Project) communication standards, although the present disclosure may apply to other communication networks.

(23) The 5G network **100**, its components, and their sub-components may be implemented via computers, servers, hardware and software modules, or other system components. The components of the 5G network **100** and its subcomponents, or the physical devices implementing them, may be co-located, remotely distributed, or any combination thereof. The elements of 5G network **100** may

include components hosted or situated in the cloud and implemented as software modules potentially distributed across one or more server devices or other physical components.

(24) The 5G network **100** is divided into two fundamental planes: a control plane **101** and a user plane **102**, each serving distinct yet interdependent roles. The control plane **101** is responsible for managing the signaling and control information necessary to establish, modify, and terminate communication sessions. The control plane **101** handles tasks such as authentication, policy enforcement, and mobility management. As such, the control plane **101** is crucial for orchestrating and controlling the NFs, ensuring efficient and secure connectivity. On the other hand, the user plane **102** deals with the actual data transmission—the movement of user data between devices and applications. It is optimized for high-throughput, low-latency data delivery, and is designed to efficiently transport user traffic. The separation of the control plane **101** and user plane **102** in the 5G network **100** enhances scalability, flexibility, and enables network slicing, allowing tailored configurations to meet diverse service requirements. Together, these planes **101** and **102** form a cohesive architecture that empowers the 5G network **100** to deliver unprecedented speed, reliability, and versatility for a wide array of applications and services.

(25) As noted above, the user plane **102** of the 5G network **100** operates in tandem with the control plane **101** to deliver efficient and seamless data transmission. For example, as illustrated, when a User Equipment (UE) **104**, which could be a smartphone or any other device, initiates a communication the user plane **102** handles the actual user data traffic. When the UE **104** initiates communication, the Radio Access Network (RAN) **106** comes into play, managing the wireless connection between the UE **104** and the network **100**, in particular the UE **104** and the Access and Mobility Management Function (AMF) **112**. The RAN **106** acts as the bridge between the user plane **102** and the control plane **101**, facilitating the establishment of communication sessions. As data travels through the RAN **106**, it encounters the User Data Function (UDF) **108**, which plays a pivotal role in processing and optimizing user data. The UDF **108** is responsible for tasks such as traffic optimization, content caching, and data transformation, enhancing the efficiency of data delivery.

(26) The UDF **108** provides the data to the Data Network (DN) **110**, which could represent the broader internet or a specific network service. The DN **110** processes and delivers the user data to its intended destination, completing the journey initiated by the UE **104**. The collaborative operation of the user plane **102**, UE **104**, RAN **106**, UDF **108**, and DN **110** ensures that data is transmitted reliably and efficiently, meeting the high-performance expectations of 5G networks. As those skilled in the art readily appreciate, the separation of user plane **102** and control plane **101** allows for flexible network configurations and optimizations, contributing to the enhanced capabilities of the 5G ecosystem.

(27) As noted above, when the UE **104** initiates a communication within the 5G network **100**, the AMF **112** coordinates the interaction. For example, when the UE **104** initiates communication or moves within the 5G network **100**, it sends signaling messages to the AMF **112**. The AMF **112** is responsible for tasks such as authentication, authorization, and mobility management. Upon receiving the signaling messages from the UE **104**, the AMF **112** validates the user's identity, checks for necessary permissions, and establishes the necessary context for the session. The AMF **112** coordinates with other network functions, such as the Session Management Function (SMF) **114** and the User Plane Function (UPF) **116**, to ensure the seamless setup and management of communication sessions. The interaction with the control plane **101** enables the UE **104** to access network services, adhere to established policies, and maintain continuous connectivity while benefiting from the advanced capabilities and optimizations offered by the 5G network architecture.

(28) The control plane **101** includes example components, nodes, or NFs. As illustrated, the control plane **101** includes the AMF **112**, the SMF **114**, the UPF **116**, an Authentication Server Function (AUSF) **118**, a Network Slice-Specific Authentication and Authorization Function (NSSAAF) **120**,

Service Communications Proxy (SCP) **122**, a Network Slice Selection Function (NSSF) **124**, Network Exposure Function (NEF) **126**, a Network Repository Function or NF Repository Function (NRF) **128**, a Policy Control Function (PCF) **130**, a Unified Data Management (UDM) **132**, and an Application Function (AF) **134**. The selection of NFs **112-134** depicted in the 5G network **100** is exemplary, and some of the NFs **112-134** may be excluded, or other NFs added to the collection, without departing from the scope of this disclosure. The various NFs **112-134** execute various operations to provide communication services to UEs, such as the UE **104**, that connects to the 5G network **100**. A network node or NF that provides service is referred to herein as a NF producer, while a network node or NF that consumes services is referred to herein as a NF consumer. A network function can be both a NF producer and a NF consumer depending on whether it is consuming or providing service.

(29) The NFs **112-134** of the 5G network **100** exchange various communications in the course of providing network services. The communications may include messaging to establish or end secured communication channels, such as transport layer security (TLS) handshakes, as well as service-based interface (SBI) communications. As used herein, SBI is the term given to the application programming interface (API) based communication that can take place between two NFs within the 5G SBA. A given NF can utilize an API call over the SBI to invoke a particular service or service operation. Communications between NFs **112-134** may be performed over network links and communication channels of the 5G network **100** that are not explicitly depicted in FIG. 1.

(30) When the UE **104** initiates communication within the 5G network **100**, the PCF **130** and the SMF **114** work collaboratively to ensure a seamless and optimized user experience. When the UE **104** initiates a communication session, the UE **104** sends signaling messages to the SMF **114** indicating the intent to establish a communication session. The SMF **114** then engages with the PCF **130** to enforce policies relevant to the specific user, application, or service. The PCF **130** is responsible for policy decision-making and evaluates the communication request based on predetermined policies, network conditions, and user profiles. The PCF **130** communicates with the SMF **114** to convey policy decisions, which are then implemented to control aspects such as QoS, traffic steering, and resource allocation. This dynamic interaction between the PCF **130** and SMF **114** is integral to providing a tailored and efficient communication experience, ensuring that policies are applied consistently across the session, and facilitating the network's ability to adapt to varying user and application requirements in real-time.

(31) Miscoordination between the SMF **114** and the PCF **130**, however, does occur. For example, miscoordination can arise when there are disruptions in the communication and data exchange between the SMF **114** and the PCF **130**. Factors such as network latency, data transmission errors, or software glitches can contribute to misalignment, leading to inconsistencies in policy decisions and session management. These disruptions can result in suboptimal QoS, inefficient resource utilization, and an overall compromise in the coherent application of policies between the PCF **130** and the SMF **114**.

(32) Turning now to FIGS. 2-3, exemplary miscoordination scenarios that result in SMF-PCF inconsistencies are illustrated. Starting with FIG. 2, an example SMF-PCF inconsistency scenario **200** is illustrated, according to an embodiment herein. As illustrated, the scenario **200** involves a SMF **214** and a PCF **230**, which may be the same or similar to the SMF **114** and the PCF **130** within the 5G network **100**. As such, the SMF **214** and the PCF **230** work collaboratively to establish and maintain a communication session for a respective UE, such as the UE **104**, within the 5G network. In the illustrated example, the SMF **214** is the NF consumer and the PCF **230** is the NF producer.

(33) When a UE initiates a communication session, the SMF **214** transmits a session request **236** to the PCF **230**, such as an “Npcf_SMPolicyControl_Create” request. The session request **236** initiates the establishment of a communication session within the 5G network between the UE and

respective end point. The session request **236** includes pertinent information for establishing the session, such as QoS requirements, user authentication details, and application-specific parameters. In other words, the session request **236** includes state data that enables the PCF **230** to make informed policy decisions and orchestrate a tailored session that meets the specific needs of the UE and associated services.

(34) When the PCF **230** receives the session request **236**, the PCF **230** establishes a communication session at a first state **238** based off of the state data provided in the session request **236**. Once the session at the first state **238** is established, the PCF **230** transmits a communication **240** to the SMF **214**, such as a response including a “**201—Created**” HTTP response code. The communication **240** typically includes details about the approved policies, QoS parameters, and any specific conditions or constraints associated with the first state **238** of the session as established. As those skilled in the art readily appreciate, the communication **240** enables the SMF **214** to synchronize its session management functions with the policies set by the PCF **230**, ensuring consistent and optimized control over the communication session throughout its duration. As illustrated, upon receipt of the communication **240**, the SMF **214** begins operating according to the policies, QoS parameters, and the like of the first state **238**.

(35) At some later point, the SMF **214** transmits a communication, such as an update **242**, to the PCF **230**. The update **242** may be a Policy Control Update Request that includes information relating to the communication session that requires an update in policies or QoS parameters. The update **242** may encompass details such as change in bandwidth requirements, priority levels, latency constraints, or other attributes associated with the user's session. Upon receipt of the update **242**, the PCF **230** processes the update **242** to dynamically adapt and enforce policies based on the evolving needs of the session, ensuring a responsive and tailored network experience for the UE and associated services. In other words, when the PCF **230** receives the update **242**, the state of the communication session is updated from the first state **238** to a second state **244**. Once the second state **244** is implemented, the PCF **230** transmits the state data in a communication **246** to the SMF **214**, for example as part of a “**200—OK**” HTTP status response message. Once the SMF **214** receives the communication **246**, the SMF **214** updates to the second state **244**. As used herein, the term “communication” may encompass any exchange between an NF consumer, here the SMF **214**, and a NF producer, here the PCF **230**. For example, a communication between these two NFs includes any internal exchanges (e.g., policy rule change by operator) or external exchanges (Rx/N7 request for corresponding N7 session or UDR/CFH notifications).

(36) At another later point, the SMF **214** may transmit a second communication, such as a second update **248**. Since the SMF **214** requests updates when the conditions or requirements of the ongoing communication session change, it can be appreciated that the SMF **214** may transmit numerous updates **242** and **248** during a given communication session. Similar to above, when the PCF **230** receives the second update **248**, the PCF **230** processes the update and modifies the session accordingly, here by updating from the second state **244** to a third state **250**.

(37) Once the third state **250** of the session is established, the PCF **230** transmits a communication **252**, which includes the associated state data for the third state **250**, to the SMF **214** so that the SMF **214** can update its state to match the third state **250**. Here, however, there is a disruption that causes the communication **252** to not be received by the SMF **214**. Network congestion or latency, resource constraints, or communication errors may result in a timeout **254**, and the PCF **230** will have no indication that the SMF **214** did not receive the communication **252**. While in some cases, the timeout **254** may trigger an error handling mechanism or procedure designed to manage the situation, prior to any resolution of the timeout **254**, the communication session continues in a state where the SMF **214** is operating according to the second state **244** and the PCF **230** is operating according to the third state **250**.

(38) The SMF **214** may send a subsequent communication **256** at a later point. However, because the PCF **230** and the SMF **214** are operating at two different states, the PCF **230** may not be able to

process the communication **256** correctly or at all. As noted above, operating in inconsistent states can lead to a variety of negative consequences for a given communication session. That is, the SMF-PCF inconsistency depicted in the scenario **200** may result in misaligned policy enforcement, leading to suboptimal resource utilization, compromised user experience, and an increased risk of service disruptions or inefficiencies in the dynamic orchestration of network functions.

(39) The SMF-PCF inconsistency may be further exacerbated by the PCF **230** receiving a notification **258**. The notification **258** may be an Rx request, UDR notification, or a Chf notification. The notification **258** may be received from another NF, such as the AF **134**, and may include an update to various policies or QoS parameters for the communication session.

Responsive to receiving the notification **258**, the PCF **230** transmits a communication, such as an update notify **260**, to the SMF **214**. The update notify **260** may notify the SMF **214** about changes in policies or conditions relating to the ongoing communication session. For example, the update notify **260** may include updates to the QoS parameters, changes in access control policies, or any other information that the SMF **214** needs to be aware of to adapt its management of the session accordingly. The SMF **214**, however, is unable to appropriately process the update notify **260** to achieve the correct state because the SMF **214** is operating according to the second state **244**.

Again, such an SMF-PCF inconsistency can result in a variety of adverse consequences.

(40) Turning now to FIG. 3, another example SMF-PCF inconsistency scenario **300** involving multiple PCFs is illustrated, according to an embodiment herein. As shown, the scenario **300** involves a SMF **314**, a first PCF **330A**, and a second PCF **330B**. The SMF **314** may be the same or similar to the SMF **114**, and the first and second PCFs **330A** and **330B** may be the same or similar to the PCF **130** operating within the 5G network **100**. As such, the SMF **314** may transmit a request **336** to the first PCF **330A** to establish a communication session. The request **336** may be similar to the request **236** and include state data containing various information needed to establish the session.

(41) Responsive to receiving the request **336**, the first PCF **330A** establishes the communication session in a first state **338**. Then the PCF **330A** transmits a communication **340** to the SMF **314** containing state information associated with the first state **338**. Upon receipt, the SMF **314** manages the communication session according to the first state **338**.

(42) Simultaneously or shortly after establishing the first state **338** for the session, the first PCF **330A** performs data replication **337** of the first state **338** to the second PCF **330B**. The replication **337** of the state data associated with the first state **338** from a first PCF **330A** to the second PCF **330B** serves as a critical mechanism to enhance the reliability, availability, and overall performance of a 5G network. For example, data replication **337** ensures high availability by providing a seamless failover mechanism; in the event of the first PCF **330A** failure, the second PCF **330B** can seamlessly take over, preventing service disruptions. Additionally, data replication **337** supports load balancing, allowing for efficient distribution of processing tasks between PCFs **330A** and **330B**, thereby optimizing resource utilization and accommodating varying workloads. Once the second PCF **330B** receives the data replication **337**, the second PCF **330B** stores the first state data **338** and begins operating accordingly.

(43) At some point, the SMF **314** transmits an update **342** to the first PCF **330A**. Responsive to receiving the update **342**, the first PCF **330A** updates to a second state **344** and transmits a communication **346** back to the SMF **314**. Similar to or the same as the communication **246**, the communication **346** contains state data associated with the second state **344** such that when the SMF **314** receives the communication **346**, the SMF **314** manages the session according to the second state **344**.

(44) As illustrated, the first PCF **330A** performs data replication **345** to replicate the state data associated with the second state **344** to the second PCF **330B**. However, before the second PCF **330B** receives and processes the data replication **345**, the second PCF **330B** receives a notification **358**. As can be appreciated, network congestion, communication errors, resource constraints, and

the like may cause delayed receipt of the data replication **345** by the second PCF **330B**. In another example, the notification **358** may be transmitted to the second PCF **330B** prior or simultaneous to the data replication **345** such that the second PCF **330B** receives notification **358** before the data replication **345**.

(45) Responsive to receiving the notification **358**, the second PCF **330B** transmits an update notify **360** to the SMF **314**. Upon receiving the update notify **360**, the SMF **314** implements a third state **350** according to the update notify **360** and transmits a response **348** to the second PCF **330B**. When the second PCF **330B** receives the response **348** from the SMF **314**, the second PCF **330B** implements the third state data, as confirmed by the response **348**.

(46) When the second PCF **330B** implements the third state data, however, the response **348** is applied to the second PCF **330B**'s current state, which is the first state **338**, not the second state **344** that the SMF **314** is working on. As such, when the second PCF **330B** updates its current state based on the third state data, a third prime state **352** is generated. As can be appreciated, depending on what state the notification **358** was intended to apply to, application of the response **348** to the first state **338**, instead of the second state **344**, is likely to result in a mismatch between the SMF **314** and the second PCF **330B**. The mismatch is further exacerbated by the second PCF **330B** performing data duplication **351** of the third prime state **352** to the first PCF **330A**. Now both the first and second PCFs **330A** and **330B** are running on inconsistent states from the SMF **314**.

(47) As is illustrated by the simplistic depiction of scenario **300**, one or more NFs can be operating according to inconsistent states in a minimal number of actions. Accordingly, it is advantageous to proactively identify and reconcile any misalignments or inconsistencies in operating states between NFs, such as the SMF **314**, the first PCF **330A**, and the second PCF **330B**.

(48) Turning now to FIGS. **4-10**, example policy tags and related functions are described for proactively detecting and reconciling inconsistencies between two or more NFs. Starting with FIG. **4**, FIG. **4** provides an operational scenario **400** illustrating use of policy tags between an NF producer and an NF consumer, according to an embodiment herein. FIG. **4** is described in tandem with FIG. **5** for illustrative purposes. FIG. **5** illustrates a process **500** for proactively detecting and reconciling inconsistencies between two or more NFs using policy tags, according to an embodiment herein. For ease of discussion, the process **500** is referred to herein as the policy tag process. Additionally, it should be appreciated that while the process **500** is described with reference to FIG. **4**, that one or more steps of the process **500** is equally applicable to any other Figure or component within a Figure provided herein.

(49) With reference to FIG. **4**, the operational scenario **400** includes two NFs, one of which operates as a NF consumer and the other operates as a NF producer. In the illustrated example, the NF consumer is a SMF **414** and the NF producer is a PCF **430**, which may be the same or similar to the SMF **114** and the PCF **130**, respectively. As such, the SMF **414** and the PCF **430** are communicatively coupled to exchange communications or messages within a 5G network, such as the 5G network **100**.

(50) At some point, the SMF **414** transmits a session request **436** to the PCF **430** to establish a session. Upon receipt of the request **436**, the PCF **430** establishes the session according to state data present within the request **436**. In particular, the PCF **430** establishes a first state **438** for the session (**505**). As part of or subsequent to establishing the first state **438**, the PCF **430** generates **464** a first policy tag (**s1t0**) for the first state **438** (**510**) and stores (**466**) the first policy tag (**s1t0**) along with the corresponding state data for the first state (**515**). When the PCF **430** stores (**466**) the first policy tag (**s1t0**), it is referred to herein as the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**). The first stored policy tag (**s1t0**) may be stored in a database (DB) associated with the PCF **430**.

(51) As described above, policy tags, such as the first policy tag (**s1t0**), provide a means for detecting inconsistencies between a NF producer, here the PCF **430**, and a NF consumer, here the SMF **414**. To detect inconsistencies, policy tags include an opaque identifier that is assigned by a server or by the NF producer, here the PCF **430**, and indicates a specific version of a resource. The

opaque identifier is opaque in that a UE or client is unaware of how each policy tag is constructed or even of the policy tag's inclusion within a communication. As such, the inclusion of the policy tag is evident only to the receiving NF consumer, here the SMF **414**.

(52) The opaque identifier of the first policy tag (**s1t0**) includes information relating to a specific version of a resource or state of the session. In the illustrated example, the opaque identifier of the first policy tag (**s1t0**) includes a site identifier (ID) and a timestamp. The site ID for the first policy tag is “s1” and the timestamp is “t0.” In some cases, a site ID refers to an NF Instance ID (e.g., “nfInstanceID”) provided by a respective NF. Although the following illustrative examples include a site ID and a timestamp in this format, those skilled in the art should readily appreciate that variations in nomenclature and format are equally contemplated herein. Additionally, variations in information included in the policy tag are also contemplated herein.

(53) By including the opaque identifier as part of the first policy tag (**s1t0**), not only can an inconsistency be determined, but the opaque identifier provides information on why the inconsistency occurred. That is, not only do policy tags allow for detection of an inconsistency, but a policy tag can provide information about what caused the inconsistency. For example, the policy tag can provide information on what state a NF is functioning according to (e.g., an old state or a new state) and which NF (a first PCF, a second PCF, or the SMF) is operating on the inconsistent state.

(54) Once the first policy tag (**s1t0**) is generated and stored, the PCF **430** transmits a communication **440** to the SMF **414** (520). As part of the communication **440**, the PCF **430** includes the first policy tag (**s1t0**). When the SMF **414** receives the communication **440**, the SMF **414** begins to manage the communication session according to the first state **438**. Additionally, the SMF **414** stores **468** the first policy tag (**s1t0**) as a first received policy tag (**s1t0**).

(55) When the SMF **414** transmits a communication, such as an update request **442** to the PCF **430**, the SMF **414** includes the most recently received policy tag, here the first received policy tag (**s1t0**). The PCF **430** receives the update request **442** from the SMF **414** (525). Upon receipt of the update request **442**, the PCF **430** identifies the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) in the update request **442** and performs a validation process **470** based on the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) (430). The validation process may include comparing the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) to the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**). In some cases, the validation process may include the PCF **430** recalling a most recently stored policy tag, here the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**), from the DB prior to comparing the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**) to the first received policy tag (**s1t0**). Comparing the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**) to the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) may include determining whether the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) matches the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**) or whether there is a mismatch between the two policy tags.

(56) Depending on the validation process, the PCF **430** processes the update request **442** accordingly (535). For example, if the PCF **430** determines that there is a match between the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) and the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**), then the PCF **430** proceeds with processing the update **472**, such as by implementing state data present in the update request **442**. If the PCF **430** determines a mismatch between the first received policy tag (**s1t0**) and the first stored policy tag (**s1t0**), then the PCF **430** may perform a reconciliation process, as will be described in greater detail with respect to FIG. 6-10.

(57) As illustrated, the PCF **430** performs the validation process **470** prior to processing the update **472** from the SMF **414**. As can be appreciated, by performing the validation process **470** prior to processing the update **472**, the PCF **430** can detect whether the SMF **414** is operating at an inconsistent state from the PCF **430**. If the SMF **414** is operating at an inconsistent state then the PCF **430** can determine an appropriate reconciliation process instead of processing the update, as is the current approach. As is evident by FIGS. 2 and 3, processing updates when the NF consumer and the NF producer are operating on inconsistent states perpetuates the issue and can amplify the inconsistency between the two NFs. As such, the PCF **430** may only process the update **472** when

the first received policy tag (s1t0) is validated as matching the first stored policy tag (s1t0), thereby indicating that both the SMF 414 and the PCF 430 are operating on consistent states.

(58) Upon processing the update 472, the PCF 430 establishes a second state 444. Along with establishing the second state 444, the PCF 430 also generates a second policy tag (s1t1) 474 and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) 476 as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The PCF 430 then transmits the second policy tag (s1t1) to the SMF 414, where the SMF 414 in turn implements the second state 444 and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) 478 as a second received policy tag (s1t1).

(59) In the illustrated scenario 400, while the SMF 414 implements the second state 444, the PCF 430 receives a notification 458, which may be the same or similar to the notification 358. Pursuant to the notification 458, the PCF 430 generates a third policy tag (s1t2) 480 and stores the third policy tag (s1t2) 482 as a third stored policy tag (s1t2). The PCF 430 then transmits the third policy tag (s1t2) to the SMF 414 along with a communication, such as an update request 460 requesting that the SMF 414 update based on state data provided in the notification 458.

(60) Upon receipt of the request 460, the SMF 414 identifies the most recently received policy tag 456. The most recently received policy tag is the policy tag that the SMF 414 most recently received and stored prior to receiving the request 460. Here, the most recently received policy tag is the second received policy tag (s1t1). Either before or after the SMF 414 responds to the PCF 430 via a response 448, the SMF 414 may implement a third state 450 and store the third policy tag (s1t2) 462 as a third received policy tag (s1t2). That is, in some cases, the SMF 414 may first establish the third state 450 and store the third received policy tag (s1t2) 462 before transmitting the response 448, while in other cases, the SMF 414 may transmit the response 448 first. In still another example, the SMF 414 may transmit the response 448 simultaneously to establishing the third state 450 and storing the third received policy tag (s1t2) 462.

(61) When responding to the request 460, the SMF 414 transmits a response 448 that includes the second received policy tag (s1t1). When the PCF 430 receives the response 448, the PCF 430 performs the validation process 484. The validation process 484 may include determining a most recently stored policy tag, here the second stored policy tag (s1t1) and comparing the second stored policy tag (s1t1) to the second received policy tag (s1t1) to each other to determine if they match.

(62) Then based on the validation process 484, the PCF 430 processes the update 486 based on the notification 458 accordingly. Here, since the second received policy tag (s1t1) received from the SMF 414 matches the second stored policy tag (s1t1), the PCF 430 determines that the two NFs are operating according to consistent states. As such, the PCF 430 processes the update 486, which in this case means implementing the third state 450.

(63) Turning now to FIGS. 6-10, example scenarios in which an inconsistency is detected, and the PCF continues to determine a reconciliation process are illustrated. Referring now to FIG. 6, an operational scenario 600 illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags is provided, according to an embodiment herein. The scenario 600 includes an NF consumer, here SMF 614, and an NF producer, here PCF 630. The SMF 614 and the PCF 630 may be the same or similar to the SMF 414 and the PCF 430, respectively. As shown, the SMF 614 transmits a session request 636 to the PCF 630 to initiate a communication session within a 5G network, such as the 5G network 100. Responsive to receiving the request 636, the PCF 630 establishes the session in a first state 638. The PCF 630 then generates and stores a first policy tag (s1t0) 665 as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(64) Once generated, the PCF 630 transmits the first policy tag (s1t0) to the SMF 614, which in turn implements the first state 638 and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) 668 as a first received policy tag (s1t0). At a later point, the SMF 614 transmits a communication, such as an update 642, along with the first received policy tag (s1t0) to the PCF 630. Upon receipt of the update 642, the PCF 630 performs a validation process 670 based on the first received policy tag (s1t0) received as part of the update 642 and the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Once validated that the two policy tags match, the PCF 630 processes the update and implements the update as a second state 644.

Responsive to implementing the second state **644**, the PCF **630** generates and stores a second policy tag (s1t1) **675** as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The PCF **630** then transmits a communication **646**, along with the second policy tag (s1t1) to the SMF **614**.

(65) Responsive to receiving the communication **646**, the SMF **614** implements the second state **644** and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) as a second received policy tag (s1t1). At a later point, the SMF **614** transmits a communication, such as an update request **648** to the PCF **630**. The update request **648** includes the second received policy tag (s1t1). Upon receipt of the update request **648**, the PCF **630** performs a validation process **684** and validates that the second received policy tag (s1t1) and the second stored policy tag (s1t1) match. Based on this validation, the PCF **630** processes the update request **648** and implements a third state **650**. Since a new state is implemented, the PCF **630** generates and stores a third policy tag (s1t2) **681** as a third stored policy tag (s1t2).

(66) Next, the PCF **630** transmits a communication **660** including the third policy tag (s1t2) to the SMF **614**. However, as illustrated, the communication **660** does not reach the SMF **614** and instead times out **654**. Since the SMF **614** doesn't receive the communication **660**, the SMF **614** is not aware that the PCF **630** implemented the third state **650** and instead continues operating according to the second state **644**. As such, when the SMF **614** transmits a communication, such as an update request **662** to the PCF **630** at some later point, the update request **662** includes the second received policy tag (s1t1).

(67) Since the SMF **614** is operating according to the second state **644** and the PCF **630** is operating according to the third state **650** as indicated by each NFs most recent policy tag, when the PCF **630** performs a validation process **684**, the PCF **630** determines an inconsistency **688**. When the PCF **630** determines an inconsistency **688**, the PCF **630** then determines a reconciliation process **690** to rectify the inconsistency. The reconciliation process **690** may rectify the identified inconsistency between the SMF **614** and the PCF **630**.

(68) The PCF **630** may initiate a reconciliation process **690** based on a variety of status information, such as the most recent stored policy tag or received policy tag, and/or a replication status with a leader NF. In some examples, the PCF **630** selects a reconciliation process **690** based on the type of inconsistency and operation configuration. For example, reconciliation process **690** may include a last-update-wins reconciliation process, termination of the communication session, merging of session records, resynchronization of states between the PCF **630** and the SMF **414**, or rebuilding the session or state at the PCF **630**. Each of these reconciliation processes are described in turn below.

(69) In an example, the PCF **630** may select the last-update-wins reconciliation process if the update **662** includes full state data. For example, if the update **662** includes all of the state data for a new state required by the PCF **630** to implement the new state. If the PCF **630** determines that the update **662** includes all necessary state data for the new state, then the PCF **630** may select the last-update-wins reconciliation process and implement the new state.

(70) In another example, the PCF **630** may determine that terminating the communication session is the appropriate reconciliation process given the operational configuration and the type of inconsistency. For example, the PCF **630** may determine that the operational configuration indicates that the communication session is a small duration session and the inconsistency with the SMF **614** is too great to implement any of the other reconciliation processes. As such, the PCF **630** may trigger a session termination process and allow the SMF **614** to request session re-establishment.

(71) In another example, the PCF **630** may determine that merging of session records or states is an appropriate reconciliation process. For example, the update request **662** may include a partial update that does not overlap with the third state **650**. As such, the PCF **630** processes the update **662** and merges the update **662** with the third state **650** to establish a fourth state (not shown). The fourth state may include the updates **662** merged with the state data of the third state **650**.

(72) In another example, the PCF **630** may determine that resynchronization of the session states is an appropriate reconciliation process. The PCF **630** may select this reconciliation process when a correct state cannot be determined locally. As such, the PCF **630** may fetch state data from respective NF producers (e.g., UDR/CHF) to rebuild the correct state. Once fetched, the PCF **630** may transmit the correct state data to the SMF **614** such that both NFs can implement the correct state data and resynchronize to the same state.

(73) In another example, the PCF **630** may determine that rebuilding the session or state is an appropriate reconciliation process. For example, the PCF **630** may have received multiple versions of each state from the SMF **614** and may have an index of the transaction history between the PCF **630** and the SMF **614**. As such, the PCF **630** can rebuild to an appropriate state based on the transaction history of session states and updates transmitted between the SMF **614** and the PCF **630**. In some cases, the PCF **630** may also fetch state data from respective NF producers (e.g., UDR/CHF) to aid in determining a correct state.

(74) Once the PCF **630** determines the appropriate reconciliation process **690**, the PCF **630** implements that reconciliation process and reconciles the inconsistency between the SMF **614** and the PCF **630**. Once reconciled, the SMF **614** and the PCF **630** continue the communication session according to the same state.

(75) Referring now to FIG. 7, another operational scenario **700** illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags is provided, according to an embodiment herein. The scenario **700** includes an NF consumer, here SMF **714**, and an NF producer, here PCF **730**. The SMF **714** and the PCF **730** may be the same or similar to the SMF **414** and the PCF **430**, respectively. As shown, the SMF **714** transmits a session request **736** to the PCF **730** to initiate a communication session within a 5G network, such as the 5g network **100**. Responsive to receiving the request **363**, the PCF **730** establishes the session in a first state **738**. The PCF **730** then generates and stores a first policy tag (s1t0) **765** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(76) Once generated, the PCF **730** transmits the first policy tag (s1t0) to the SMF **714**, which in turn implements the first state **738** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **768** as a first received policy tag (s1t0). At a later point, the SMF **714** transmits an update **742** along with the first received policy tag (s1t0) to the PCF **730**. Upon receipt of the update **742**, the PCF **730** performs a validation process **770** based on the first received policy tag (s1t0) received as part of the update **742** and the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Once validated that the two policy tags match, the PCF **730** processes the update and implements the update as a second state **744**. Responsive to implementing the second state **744**, the PCF **730** generates and stores a second policy tag (s1t1) **775** as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The PCF **730** then transmits a communication **746** including the second policy tag (s1t1) to the SMF **714**. The SMF **714**, however, does not receive the communication **746** due to a timeout **754**. As such, the SMF **714** continues operating according to the first state **738**.

(77) At a subsequent time, the PCF **730** receives a notification **758**, which may be the same as the notification **358**. Responsive to the notification **758**, the PCF **730** generates and stores a third policy tag (s1t2) **781** as a third stored policy tag (s1t2). The PCF **730** then transmits a communication **760** (e.g., an update request) including the third policy tag (s1t2) to the SMF **714**. Responsive to receiving the communication **760**, the SMF **714** determines a most recently received policy tag **756**. The most recently received policy tag is the policy tag that was most recently received before the communication **760** was received. In other words, as used herein, the most recently received policy tag is not the policy tag that is included in the communication **760**. Because the SMF **714** did not receive the second policy tag (s1t1) from the PCF **730** due to the time out **754**, the SMF **714** identifies the most recently received policy tag as the first received policy tag (s1t0) **756**.

(78) As noted above, the SMF **714** then establishes a third state **750** based on the communication **760** and stores the third policy tag (s1t2) **762** as a third received policy tag (s1t2). Simultaneously,

prior to, or directly subsequent to establishing the third state **750** and storing the third received policy tag (s1t2) **762**, the SMF **714** transmits a response **748** including the identified most recently received policy tag (s1t0) to the PCF **730**.

(79) Since the SMF **714** is operating according to the first state **738** and the PCF **730** is operating according to the second state **744**, as indicated by each NFs most recent policy tag, when the PCF **730** performs a validation process **784**, the PCF **730** determines an inconsistency **788**. When the PCF **730** determines an inconsistency **788**, the PCF **730** then determines one or more reconciliation processes **790** to rectify the inconsistency. As noted above, the PCF **730** selects a reconciliation process based on the type of inconsistency and the operational configuration of the NFs. In the illustrated example, the PCF **730** determines that the last-update-wins reconciliation process is an appropriate reconciliation process and as such, the PCF **730** updates to the third state **750**.

(80) As can be appreciated, there may be scenarios in which the timeout **754** does not occur and the SMF **714** receives the communication **746**. Upon receipt of the communication **748** which includes the second policy tag (s1t1), the SMF **714** may store the second policy tag (s1t1) and update to the second state **744**. At a later time in this scenario, the PCF **730** may transmit the communication **760** including the third policy tag (s1t2) to the SMF **714**, to which the SMF **714** transmits the response **748**. In this scenario, however, the response **748** may timeout (not shown) and thus the PCF **730** may not receive the response **748**. Because the PCF **730** does not receive the response **748** from the SMF **714**, the PCF **730** will continue operating according to the second state **744** and may not update to the third state (**750**). As such, at a later point when the PCF **730** and the SMF **714** exchange state information, and each provides a most recently stored policy tag, the validation process **784** may be performed to identify the inconsistency between the SFM **714** and the PCF **730** as described above.

(81) Turning now to FIG. **8**, an operational scenario **800** illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs is provided, according to an embodiment herein. The scenario **800** includes an NF consumer, here SMF **814**, a first NF producer, here PCF **830A**, and a second NF producer, here PCF **830B**. The SMF **814** may be the same or similar to the SMF **414**, and the first PCF **830A** and the second PCF **830B** may be the same or similar to the PCF **430**. As shown, the SMF **814** transmits a session request **836** to the first PCF **830A** to initiate a communication session within a 5G network, such as the 5g network **100**. Responsive to receiving the request **836**, the first PCF **830A** establishes the session in a first state **838**. The first PCF **830A** then generates and stores a first policy tag (s1t0) **865** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(82) Once generated, the first PCF **830A** transmits the first policy tag (s1t0) to the SMF **814**, which in turn implements the first state **838** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **868** as a first received policy tag (s1t0). The first PCF **830A** also transmits a data replication **837** to the second PCF **830B**. Upon receipt, the second PCF **830B** implements the first state **838** based on the data replication **837** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **857** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0) by the second PCF **830B**.

(83) At a later point, the SMF **814** transmits a communication, such as an update **842**, along with the first received policy tag (s1t0) to the first PCF **830A**. Upon receipt of the update **842**, the first PCF **830A** performs a validation process **870** based on the first received policy tag (s1t0) received as part of the update **842** and the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Once validated that the two policy tags match, the first PCF **830A** processes the update and implements the update as a second state **844**. Responsive to implementing the second state **844**, the first PCF **830A** generates and stores a second policy tag (s1t1) **875** as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The first PCF **830A** then transmits the second policy tag (s1t1) **846** to the SMF **814**. Responsive to receiving the communication **846**, the SMF **814** implements the second state **844** and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) as a second received policy tag (s1t1).

(84) As shown, the first PCF **830A** attempts to replicate data **845** corresponding to the second state **844** to the second PCF **830B**, however, the replication fails to be received by the second PCF **830B**. As noted above, the failure to replicate data **845** to the second PCF **830B** could be due to a variety

of disruptions, such as network congestion, resource constraints, communication errors, and the like. Because the second PCF **830B** does not receive the replicated data **845**, the second PCF **830B** continues to operate according to the first state **838**, while the first PCF **830A** and the SMF **814** operate according to the second state **844**.

(85) At a subsequent time, the SMF **814** transmits a communication, such as an update request **848** to the second PCF **830B**. The update request **848** includes the second received policy tag **878**. Upon receipt of the update request **848**, the second PCF **830B** performs a validation process **884**. Since the SMF **814** is operating according to the second state **844** and the second PCF **830B** is operating according to the first state **838** as indicated by each NFs most recent policy tag, when the second PCF **830B** performs a validation process **784**, the second PCF **830B** determines an inconsistency **888**. When the second PCF **830B** determines an inconsistency **888**, the second PCF **830B** then determines one or more reconciliation processes **890** to rectify the inconsistency. As noted above, the second PCF **830B** selects a reconciliation process based on the type of inconsistency and the operational configuration of the NFs.

(86) Turning now to FIG. **9**, another operational scenario **900** illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs is provided, according to an embodiment herein. The scenario **900** includes an NF consumer, here SMF **914**, a first NF producer, here PCF **930A**, and a second NF producer, here PCF **930B**. The SMF **914** may be the same or similar to the SMF **414**, and the first PCF **930A** and the second PCF **930B** may be the same or similar to the PCF **430**. As shown, the SMF **914** transmits a session request **936** to the first PCF **930A** to initiate a communication session within a 5G network, such as the 5G network **100**. Responsive to receiving the request **936**, the first PCF **930A** establishes the session in a first state **938**. The first PCF **930A** then generates **964** and stores a first policy tag (s1t0) **966** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(87) Once generated, the first PCF **930A** transmits the first policy tag (s1t0) to the SMF **914**, which in turn implements the first state **938** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **968** as a first received policy tag (s1t0). The first PCF **930A** also transmits a data replication **937** to the second PCF **930B**. Upon receipt, the second PCF **930B** implements the first state **938** based on the data replication **937** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **957** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0) by the second PCF **930B**.

(88) At a later point, the SMF **914** transmits an update **942** along with the first stored policy tag (s1t0) to the first PCF **930A**. Upon receipt of the update **942**, the first PCF **930A** performs a validation process **970** based on the first received policy tag (s1t0) received as part of the update **942** and the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Once validated that the two policy tags match, the first PCF **930A** processes the update and implements the update as a second state **944**. Responsive to implementing the second state **944**, the first PCF **930A** generates **974** and stores a second policy tag (s1t1) **976** as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The first PCF **930A** then transmits the second policy tag (s1t1) **946** to the SMF **914**. Responsive to receiving the communication **946**, the SMF **914** implements the second state **944** and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) as a second received policy tag (s1t1) **978**.

(89) As shown, the first PCF **930A** attempts to replicate data **945** corresponding to the second state **944** to the second PCF **930B**, however, the replication fails to be received by the second PCF **930B**. As noted above, the failure to replicate data **945** to the second PCF **930B** could be due to a variety of disruptions, such as network congestion, resource constraints, communication errors, and the like. Because the second PCF **930B** does not receive the replicated data **945**, the second PCF **930B** continues to operate according to the first state **938**, while the first PCF **930A** and the SMF **914** operate according to the second state **944**.

(90) At a subsequent time, the second PCF **930B** receives a notification **958**, which may be the same or similar to the notification **358**. Responsive to the notification **958**, the second PCF **930B** generates a third policy tag (s2t5) **980** and stores the third policy tag (s2t5) **982** as a third stored policy tag (s2t5). The second PCF **930B** transmits a communication **960** (e.g., an update request) along with the third policy tag (s2t5) to the SMF **914**.

(91) Upon receipt of the communication **960** from the second PCF **930B**, the SMF **914** may implement the third state **950** and store the third policy tag (s2t5) **962** as a third stored policy tag (s2t5). Subsequently or simultaneously, the SMF **914** identifies a most recently received policy tag prior to receiving the communication **960**, here the second received policy tag (s1t1) **956**. The SMF **914** then transmits a response **948** along with the second received policy tag (s1t1) to the second PCF **930B**. The second PCF **930B** then performs a validation process **984** to verify that the second received policy tag (s1t1) matches its most recently stored policy tag, here the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Because the data replication **945** of the second state **944** failed to be received by the second PCF **930B**, the second PCF **930B** is still operating according to the first state **938**. As such, during the validation process **984**, the second PCF **930B** determines a most recently stored policy tag (e.g., the most recent stored policy tag prior to receiving the notification **958**) and compares the recently stored policy tag to the most recently received policy tag that is part of the communication **948**.

(92) Because the second PCF **930B** and the SMF **914** are operating on two different states, the second PCF **930B** determines an inconsistency **988**. Pursuant to the inconsistency **988**, the second PCF **930B** determines an appropriate reconciliation process **990** based on the type of the inconsistency and other session information, as described above. Here, the second PCF **930B** may determine that the state data provided in the notification **958** and/or the SMF **914** includes enough state data that the third state **950** is implemented.

(93) Turning now to FIG. **10**, another operational scenario **1000** illustrating detection of an inconsistency using policy tags involving multiple PCFs is provided, according to an embodiment herein. The scenario **1000** includes an NF consumer, here SMF **1014**, a first NF producer, here PCF **1030A**, and a second NF producer, here PCF **1030B**. The SMF **1014** may be the same or similar to the SMF **414**, and the first PCF **1030A** and the second PCF **1030B** may be the same or similar to the PCF **430**. As shown, the SMF **1014** transmits a session request **1036** to the first PCF **1030A** to initiate a communication session within a 5G network, such as the 5g network **100**. Responsive to receiving the request **1036**, the first PCF **1030A** establishes the session in a first state **1038**. The first PCF **1030A** then generates **1064** and stores a first policy tag (s1t0) **1066** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(94) Once generated, the first PCF **1030A** transmits the first policy tag (s1t0) to the SMF **1014**, which in turn implements the first state **1038** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **1068** as a first received policy tag (s1t0). The first PCF **1030A** also transmits a data replication **1037** to the second PCF **1030B**. Upon receipt, the second PCF **1030B** implements the first state **1038** based on the data replication **1037** and stores the first policy tag (s1t0) **1057** as a first stored policy tag (s1t0).

(95) At a later point, the SMF **1014** transmits a communication, such as an update **1042**, along with the first received policy tag (s1t0) to the first PCF **1030A**. Upon receipt of the update **1042**, the first PCF **1030A** performs a validation process **1070** based on the first received policy tag (s1t0) received as part of the update **1042** and the first stored policy tag (s1t0). Once validated that the two policy tags match, the first PCF **1030A** processes the update and implements the update as a second state **1044**. Responsive to implementing the second state **1044**, the first PCF **1030A** generates **1074** and stores a second policy tag (s1t1) **1076** as a second stored policy tag (s1t1). The first PCF **1030A** then transmits the second policy tag (s1t1) **1046** to the SMF **1014**. Responsive to receiving the communication **1046**, the SMF **1014** implements the second state **1044** and stores the second policy tag (s1t1) as a second received policy tag (s1t1).

(96) As shown, the first PCF **1030A** attempts to replicate data **1045** corresponding to the second state **1044** to the second PCF **1030B**, however, the replication fails to be received by the second PCF **1030B**. As noted above, the failure to replicate data **1045** to the second PCF **1030B** could be due to a variety of disruptions, such as network congestion, resource constraints, communication errors, and the like. Because the second PCF **1030B** does not receive the replicated data **1045**, the second PCF **1030B** continues to operate according to the first state **1038**, while the first PCF **1030A**

and the SMF **1014** operate according to the second state **1044**.

(97) The second PCF **1030B** operates according to the first state **1038** until it receives a notification **1058**. Responsive to the notification **1058**, the second PCF **1030B** generates a third policy tag (s2t5) **1080**. The second PCF **1030B** stores the third policy tag (s2t5) as a third stored policy tag (s2t5) **1082**. The second PCF **1030B** then transmits a communication **1060** to the SMF **1014**. The communication **1060** may be an update request based on the notification **1058** that includes the third policy tag (s2t5) **1060**.

(98) At the same time or at a time before the second PCF **1030B** receives a notification **1058** and transmits the communication **1060** to the SMF **1014**, the first PCF **1030A** transmits a communication **1046** to the SMF **1014** including the second policy tag (s1t1). The communication **1046** is received by the SMF **1014** at the same time that the communication **1060** from the second PCF **1030B** is received. In this scenario **1000**, the SMF **1014** receives the communication **1046** slightly before the communication **1060** and as such begins implementing the second state **1044**. As such, the SMF **1014** may continue managing the session according to the second state **1044** and store the second policy tag (s1t1) **1078** as the second received policy tag (s1t1).

(99) At a time after the SMF **1014** has established the second state **1044**, the SMF **1014** identifies **1059** a most recently received policy tag, here the second received policy tag (s1t1) and transmits a communication **1048**, such as a response to the communication **1060**, along with a most recently received policy tag to the second PCF **1030B**. When the second PCF **1030B** receives the response **1048**, the second PCF **1030B** performs a validation process **1084** and determines an inconsistency **1088** based on its most recently stored policy tag, here the first stored policy tag (s1t0), and the second received policy tag (s1t1). When the second PCF **1030B** determines an inconsistency **1088**, the second PCF **1030B** then determines one or more reconciliation processes **1090** to rectify the inconsistency. As noted above, the second PCF **1030B** selects a reconciliation process based on the type of inconsistency and the operational configuration of the NFs.

(100) As exemplified by each of the operational scenarios in FIGS. **6-10**, policy tags allow NFs to detect inconsistencies between NF states and reconcile the states to avoid adverse impacts of NF inconsistencies. Although in the above scenarios, the PCFs generate respective policy tags, it should be appreciated that in some scenarios, the SMF may generate a policy tag. In other words, although the above description and respective illustrations show the NF producer as a PCF for ease of explanation, in some cases, the NF producer may be an SMF, AMF, UDR, NWDAF, or any other NF producer that exchanges session states with a NF consumer through service requests.

(101) Referring now to FIG. **11**, is a diagram of a system **1100** configured to implement policy tags and their related functions, according to an embodiment herein. The system **1100** may be an example of an apparatus including a computing system **1101** that is representative of any system or collection of systems in which the various processes, systems, programs, services, and scenarios disclosed herein may be implemented. For example, computing system **1101** may be an example of one or more NFs within the 5G network **100** of FIG. **1**, such as the PCF **130** or the SMF **114**. Examples of computing system **1101** include, but are not limited to, server computers, desktop computers, laptop computers, routers, switches, web servers, cloud computing platforms, and data center equipment, as well as any other type of physical or virtual server machine, physical or virtual router, container, and any variation or combination thereof.

(102) Computing system **1101** may be implemented as a single apparatus, system, or device or may be implemented in a distributed manner as multiple apparatuses, systems, or devices. Computing system **1101** may include, but is not limited to, processing system **1102**, storage system **1103**, software **1105**, communication interface system **1107**, and user interface system **1109**. Processing system **1102** may be operatively coupled with storage system **1103**, communication interface system **1107**, and user interface system **1109**.

(103) Processing system **1102** may load and execute software **1105** from storage system **1103**. Software **1105** may include policy tag process **1106**, which may be representative of any of the

operations for providing a policy tag and/or detecting an inconsistency using one or more policy tags, as discussed with respect to the preceding figures. When executed by processing system **1102**, software **1105** may direct processing system **1102** to operate as described herein for at least the various processes, such as the process **500**, operational scenarios, and sequences discussed in the foregoing implementations. Computing system **1101** may optionally include additional devices, features, or functionality not discussed for purposes of brevity.

(104) In some embodiments, processing system **1102** may comprise a micro-processor and other circuitry that retrieves and executes software **1105** from storage system **1103**. Processing system **1102** may be implemented within a single processing device but may also be distributed across multiple processing devices or sub-systems that cooperate in executing program instructions. Examples of processing system **1102** may include general purpose central processing units, graphical processing units, application specific processors, and logic devices, as well as any other type of processing device, combinations, or variations thereof.

(105) Storage system **1103** may comprise any memory device or computer readable storage media readable by processing system **1102** and capable of storing software **1105**. Storage system **1103** may include volatile and nonvolatile, removable and non-removable media implemented in any method or technology for storage of information, such as computer readable instructions, data structures, program modules, or other data. Examples of storage media include random access memory, read only memory, magnetic disks, optical disks, optical media, flash memory, virtual memory and non-virtual memory, magnetic cassettes, magnetic tape, magnetic disk storage or other magnetic storage devices, or any other suitable storage media. In no case is the computer readable storage media a propagated signal.

(106) In addition to computer readable storage media, in some implementations storage system **1103** may also include computer readable communication media over which at least some of software **1105** may be communicated internally or externally. Storage system **1103** may be implemented as a single storage device but may also be implemented across multiple storage devices or sub-systems co-located or distributed relative to each other. Storage system **1103** may comprise additional elements, such as a controller, capable of communicating with processing system **1102** or possibly other systems.

(107) Software **1105** (including the policy tag process **1106** among other functions) may be implemented in program instructions that may, when executed by processing system **1102**, direct processing system **1102** to operate as described with respect to the various operational scenarios, sequences, and processes illustrated herein.

(108) In particular, the program instructions may include various components or modules that cooperate or otherwise interact to carry out the various processes and operational scenarios described herein. The various components or modules may be embodied in compiled or interpreted instructions, or in some other variation or combination of instructions. The various components or modules may be executed in a synchronous or asynchronous manner, serially or in parallel, in a single threaded environment or multi-threaded, or in accordance with any other suitable execution paradigm, variation, or combination thereof. Software **1105** may include additional processes, programs, or components, such as operating system software, virtualization software, or other application software. Software **1105** may also comprise firmware or some other form of machine-readable processing instructions executable by processing system **1102**.

(109) In general, software **1105** may, when loaded into processing system **1102** and executed, transform a suitable apparatus, system, or device (of which computing system **1101** is representative) overall from a general-purpose computing system into a special-purpose computing system as described herein. Indeed, encoding software **1105** on storage system **1103** may transform the physical structure of storage system **1103**. The specific transformation of the physical structure may depend on various factors in different implementations of this description. Examples of such factors may include, but are not limited to, the technology used to implement the storage media of

storage system **1103** and whether the computer-storage media are characterized as primary or secondary storage, as well as other factors.

(110) For example, if the computer readable storage media are implemented as semiconductor-based memory, software **1105** may transform the physical state of the semiconductor memory when the program instructions are encoded therein, such as by transforming the state of transistors, capacitors, or other discrete circuit elements constituting the semiconductor memory. A similar transformation may occur with respect to magnetic or optical media. Other transformations of physical media are possible without departing from the scope of the present description, with the foregoing examples provided only to facilitate the present discussion.

(111) Communication interface system **1107** may include communication connections and devices that allow for communication with other computing systems (not shown) over communication networks (not shown). Examples of connections and devices that together allow for inter-system communication may include network interface cards, antennas, power amplifiers, radio-frequency (RF) circuitry, transceivers, and other communication circuitry. The connections and devices may communicate over communication media to exchange communications with other computing systems or networks of systems, such as metal, glass, air, or any other suitable communication media.

(112) Communication between the computing system **1101** and other computing systems (not shown), may occur over a communication network or networks and in accordance with various communication protocols, combinations of protocols, or variations thereof. Examples include intranets, internets, the Internet, local area networks, wide area networks, wireless networks, wired networks, virtual networks, software defined networks, data center buses and backplanes, or any other type of network, combination of network, or variation thereof. The aforementioned communication networks and protocols are well known and need not be discussed at length here.

(113) While some examples of methods and systems herein are described in terms of software executing on various machines, the methods and systems may also be implemented as specifically-configured hardware, such as field-programmable gate array (FPGA) specifically to execute the various methods according to this disclosure. For example, examples can be implemented in digital electronic circuitry, or in computer hardware, firmware, software, or in a combination thereof. In one example, a device may include a processor or processors. The processor comprises a computer-readable medium, such as a random access memory (RAM) coupled to the processor. The processor executes computer-executable program instructions stored in memory, such as executing one or more computer programs. Such processors may comprise a microprocessor, a digital signal processor (DSP), an application-specific integrated circuit (ASIC), field programmable gate arrays (FPGAs), and state machines. Such processors may further comprise programmable electronic devices such as PLCs, programmable interrupt controllers (PICs), programmable logic devices (PLDs), programmable read-only memories (PROMs), electronically programmable read-only memories (EPROMs or EEPROMs), or other similar devices.

(114) Such processors may comprise, or may be in communication with, media, for example one or more non-transitory computer-readable media, which may store processor-executable instructions that, when executed by the processor, can cause the processor to perform methods according to this disclosure as carried out, or assisted, by a processor. Examples of non-transitory computer-readable medium may include, but are not limited to, an electronic, optical, magnetic, or other storage device capable of providing a processor, such as the processor in a web server, with processor-executable instructions. Other examples of non-transitory computer-readable media include, but are not limited to, a floppy disk, CD-ROM, magnetic disk, memory chip, ROM, RAM, ASIC, configured processor, all optical media, all magnetic tape or other magnetic media, or any other medium from which a computer processor can read. The processor, and the processing, described may be in one or more structures, and may be dispersed through one or more structures. The processor may comprise code to carry out methods (or parts of methods) according to this

disclosure.

(115) As will be appreciated by one skilled in the art, aspects of the present invention may be embodied as a system, method, computer program product, and other configurable systems. Accordingly, aspects of the present invention may take the form of an entirely hardware embodiment, an entirely software embodiment (including firmware, resident software, micro-code, etc.) or an embodiment combining software and hardware aspects that may all generally be referred to herein as a “circuit,” “module” or “system.” Furthermore, aspects of the present invention may take the form of a computer program product embodied in one or more memory devices or computer readable medium(s) having computer readable program code embodied thereon.

(116) The foregoing examples and descriptions are described herein in the context of systems and methods for providing one or more functions of using a policy tag for SMF-PCF inconsistency detection/reconciliation or providing a policy tag. Those of ordinary skill in the art will realize that these descriptions are illustrative only and are not intended to be in any way limiting. Reference is made in detail to implementations of examples as illustrated in the accompanying drawings. The same reference indicators are used throughout the drawings and the description to refer to the same or like items.

(117) In the interest of clarity, not all of the routine features of the examples described herein are shown and described. It will, of course, be appreciated that in the development of any such actual implementation, numerous implementation-specific decisions must be made in order to achieve the developer's specific goals, such as compliance with application- and business-related constraints, and that these specific goals will vary from one implementation to another and from one developer to another. That is, the foregoing description of some examples has been presented only for the purpose of illustration and description and is not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the disclosure to the precise forms disclosed. Numerous modifications and adaptations thereof will be apparent to those skilled in the art without departing from the spirit and scope of the disclosure.

(118) Reference herein to an example or implementation means that a particular feature, structure, operation, or other characteristic described in connection with the example may be included in at least one implementation of the disclosure. The disclosure is not restricted to the particular examples or implementations described as such. The appearance of the phrases “in one example,” “in an example,” “in an embodiment,” or “in an implementation,” or variations of the same in various places in the specification does not necessarily refer to the same example or implementation. Any particular feature, structure, operation, or other characteristic described in this specification in relation to one example or implementation may be combined with other features, structures, operations, or other characteristics described in respect of any other example or implementation.

(119) Use herein of the word “or” is intended to cover inclusive and exclusive OR conditions. In other words, A or B or C includes any or all of the following alternative combinations as appropriate for a particular usage: A alone; B alone; C alone; A and B only; A and C only; B and C only; and A and B and C.

(120) Unless the context clearly requires otherwise, throughout the description and the claims, the words “comprise,” “comprising,” and the like are to be construed in an inclusive sense, as opposed to an exclusive or exhaustive sense; that is to say, in the sense of “including, but not limited to.” As used herein, the terms “connected,” “coupled,” or any variant thereof means any connection or coupling, either direct or indirect, between two or more elements; the coupling or connection between the elements can be physical, logical, or a combination thereof. Additionally, the words “herein,” “above,” “below,” and words of similar import, when used in this application, refer to this application as a whole and not to any particular portions of this application. Where the context permits, words in the above Detailed Description using the singular or plural number may also include the plural or singular number respectively. The word “or,” in reference to a list of two or more items, covers all the following interpretations of the word: any of the items in the list, all the

items in the list, and any combination of the items in the list.

(121) The above Detailed Description of examples of the technology is not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the technology to the precise form disclosed above. While specific examples for the technology are described above for illustrative purposes, various equivalent modifications are possible within the scope of the technology, as those skilled in the relevant art will recognize. For example, while processes or blocks are presented in a given order, alternative implementations may perform routines having steps, or employ systems having blocks, in a different order, and some processes or blocks may be deleted, moved, added, subdivided, combined, and/or modified to provide alternative or sub combinations. Each of these processes or blocks may be implemented in a variety of different ways. Also, while processes or blocks are at times shown as being performed in series, these processes or blocks may instead be performed or implemented in parallel, or may be performed at different times. Further any specific numbers noted herein are only examples: alternative implementations may employ differing values or ranges.

(122) The teachings of the technology provided herein can be applied to other systems, not necessarily the system described above. The elements and acts of the various examples described above can be combined to provide further implementations of the technology. Some alternative implementations of the technology may include not only additional elements to those implementations noted above, but also may include fewer elements.

(123) To reduce the number of claims, certain aspects of the technology are presented below in certain claim forms, but the applicant contemplates the various aspects of the technology in any number of claim forms. For example, while only one aspect of the technology is recited as a computer-readable medium claim, other aspects may likewise be embodied as a computer-readable medium claim, or in other forms, such as being embodied in a means-plus-function claim. Any claims intended to be treated under 35 U.S.C. § 112 (f) will begin with the words “means for” but use of the term “for” in any other context is not intended to invoke treatment under 35 U.S.C. § 112 (f). Accordingly, the applicant reserves the right to pursue additional claims after filing this application to pursue such additional claim forms, in either this application or in a continuing application.

Examples

(124) These illustrative examples are mentioned not to limit or define the scope of this disclosure, but rather to provide examples to aid understanding thereof. Illustrative examples are discussed above in the Detailed Description, which provides further description. Advantages offered by various examples may be further understood by examining this specification.

(125) As used below, any reference to a series of examples is to be understood as a reference to each of those examples disjunctively (e.g., “Examples 1-4” is to be understood as “Examples 1, 2, 3, or 4”).

(126) Example 1 is a network function (NF) producer comprising: a non-transitory computer-readable medium; and one or more processors communicatively coupled to the non-transitory computer-readable medium and configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: establish a first state with an NF consumer, wherein the NF producer and the NF consumer are in a 5G network; generate a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; store the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmit a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receive a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; perform a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.

(127) Example 2 is the NF producer of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-

executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to establish a second state based on the communication; and the one or more processors are further configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: generate a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmit a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag, wherein the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp and the second opaque identifier comprises the first site identifier and a second timestamp.

(128) Example 3 is the NF producer of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the processor-executable instructions to perform the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: retrieve the first stored policy tag; compare the first stored policy tag with the first received policy tag; and validate that the first stored policy tag matches the first received policy tag.

(129) Example 4 is the NF producer of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the validation process indicates a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: determine a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer based on the mismatch; and initiate a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises one of: terminate the first state; merge the first state with another state; re-synchronize states with the NF consumer; or rebuild the first state by fetching state data from one or more other NF producers.

(130) Example 5 is the NF producer of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: determine a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer; and initiate a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises: determine a most recent update; and establish an updated state based on the most recent update.

(131) Example 6 is the NF producer of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: receive a communication that requires an update from the NF consumer; generate a second policy tag comprising a second opaque identifier; and transmit, to the NF consumer, a request for the update, wherein: the request for the update comprises the second policy tag; and the second opaque identifier is different than the first opaque identifier.

(132) Example 7 is a method comprising: establishing, by a NF producer, a first state with an NF consumer, wherein the NF producer and the NF consumer are in a 5G network; generating, by a NF producer, a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; storing, by the NF producer, the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmitting, by the NF producer, a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receiving, by the NF producer, a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; performing, by the NF producer, a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.

(133) Example 8 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the method further comprises receiving, from the NF consumer, a first request comprising request state data;

and establishing, by the NF producer, the first state with the NF consumer further comprises: establishing, by the NF producer, the first state with the NF consumer responsive to receiving the first request, wherein the first state is established based on the request state data.

(134) Example 9 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: performing, by the NF producer, the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer comprises determining a match between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises establishing a second state, by the NF producer, based on the communication from the NF consumer responsive to determining the match.

(135) Example 10 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises establishing, by the NF producer, a second state; and the method further comprises: generating, by the NF producer, a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmitting, by the NF producer, a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag.

(136) Example 11 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp.

(137) Example 12 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: performing, by the NF producer, the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer comprises determining a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises: determining, by the NF producer, a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer; and initiating, by the NF producer, a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer.

(138) Example 13 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the NF producer is a Policy Control Function (PCF); and the NF consumer is a Session Management Function (SMF).

(139) Example 14 is the method of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the validation process indicates a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises: determining, by the NF producer, a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer based on the mismatch; and initiating, by the NF producer, a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises one of: terminating the first state; merging the first state with another state; re-synchronizing states with the NF consumer; or rebuilding the first state by fetching state data from one or more other NF producers.

(140) Example 15 is a non-transitory computer-readable medium comprising processor-executable instructions configured to cause one or more processors to: establish, with a NF consumer, a first state within a 5G network; generate a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; store the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmit a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receive a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; perform a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.

(141) Example 16 is the non-transitory computer-readable medium of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to receive, from the NF consumer, a first request comprising request state data; and the processor-executable

instructions to establish, with the NF consumer, the first state further cause the one or more processors to establish the first state with the NF consumer responsive to receiving the first request, wherein the first state is established based on the request state data.

(142) Example 17 is the non-transitory computer-readable medium of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the processor-executable instructions to perform the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer further cause the one or more processors to: retrieve the first stored policy tag; compare the first stored policy tag with the first received policy tag; and validate that the first stored policy tag matches the first received policy tag.

(143) Example 18 is the non-transitory computer-readable medium of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag further cause the one or more processors to establish a second state based on the communication; and the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to: generate a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmit a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag.

(144) Example 19 is the non-transitory computer-readable medium of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to: receive a communication that requires an update communication from the NF consumer; generate a second policy tag comprising a second opaque identifier; and transmit, to the NF consumer, a request for the update communication, wherein: the request for the update communication comprises the second policy tag; and the second opaque identifier is different than the first opaque identifier.

(145) Example 20 is the non-transitory computer-readable medium of any previous or subsequent Example, wherein: the NF consumer is selected from one of: a Policy Control Function (PCF); or a Session Management Function (SMF); and the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp.

Claims

1. A network function (NF) producer comprising: a non-transitory computer-readable medium; and one or more processors communicatively coupled to the non-transitory computer-readable medium and configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: establish a first state with an NF consumer, wherein the NF producer and the NF consumer are in a 5G network; generate a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; store the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmit a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receive a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; perform a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.
2. The NF producer of claim 1, wherein: the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to establish a second state based on the communication; and the one or more processors are further configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: generate a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmit a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag, wherein the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp and the

second opaque identifier comprises the first site identifier and a second timestamp.

3. The NF producer of claim 1, wherein the processor-executable instructions to perform the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: retrieve the first stored policy tag; compare the first stored policy tag with the first received policy tag; and validate that the first stored policy tag matches the first received policy tag.

4. The NF producer of claim 1, wherein: the validation process indicates a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: determine a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer based on the mismatch; and initiate a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises one of: terminate the first state; merge the first state with another state; re-synchronize states with the NF consumer; or rebuild the first state by fetching state data from one or more other NF producers.

5. The NF producer of claim 1, wherein the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag cause the one or more processors to further execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: determine a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer; and initiate a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises: determine a most recent update; and establish an updated state based on the most recent update.

6. The NF producer of claim 1, wherein the one or more processors are further configured to execute processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium to: receive a communication that requires an update from the NF consumer; generate a second policy tag comprising a second opaque identifier; and transmit, to the NF consumer, a request for the update, wherein: the request for the update comprises the second policy tag; and the second opaque identifier is different than the first opaque identifier.

7. A method comprising: establishing, by a NF producer, a first state with an NF consumer, wherein the NF producer and the NF consumer are in a 5G network; generating, by a NF producer, a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; storing, by the NF producer, the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmitting, by the NF producer, a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receiving, by the NF producer, a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; performing, by the NF producer, a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.

8. The method of claim 7, wherein: the method further comprises receiving, from the NF consumer, a first request comprising request state data; and establishing, by the NF producer, the first state with the NF consumer further comprises: establishing, by the NF producer, the first state with the NF consumer responsive to receiving the first request, wherein the first state is established based on the request state data.

9. The method of claim 7, wherein: performing, by the NF producer, the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer comprises determining a match between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises establishing a second state, by the NF producer, based on the communication from the NF consumer responsive to determining the match.

10. The method of claim 7, wherein: processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on

the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises establishing, by the NF producer, a second state; and the method further comprises: generating, by the NF producer, a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmitting, by the NF producer, a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag.

11. The method of claim 7, wherein the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp.

12. The method of claim 7, wherein: performing, by the NF producer, the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer comprises determining a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises: determining, by the NF producer, a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer; and initiating, by the NF producer, a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer.

13. The method of claim 7, wherein: the NF producer is a Policy Control Function (PCF); and the NF consumer is a Session Management Function (SMF).

14. The method of claim 7, wherein the validation process indicates a mismatch between the first stored policy tag and the first received policy tag; and processing, by the NF producer, the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag comprises: determining, by the NF producer, a state inconsistency between the NF producer and the NF consumer based on the mismatch; and initiating, by the NF producer, a reconciliation process between the NF producer and the NF consumer, wherein the reconciliation process comprises one of: terminating the first state; merging the first state with another state; re-synchronizing states with the NF consumer; or rebuilding the first state by fetching state data from one or more other NF producers.

15. A non-transitory computer-readable medium comprising processor-executable instructions configured to cause one or more processors to: establish, with a NF consumer, a first state in a 5G network; generate a first policy tag corresponding to the first state, wherein the first policy tag comprises a first opaque identifier; store the first policy tag as a first stored policy tag; transmit a first communication to the NF consumer, wherein the first communication comprises first state data and the first policy tag; receive a communication from the NF consumer, wherein the communication comprises a first received policy tag; perform a validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer; and process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag.

16. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein: the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to receive, from the NF consumer, a first request comprising request state data; and the processor-executable instructions to establish, with the NF consumer, the first state further cause the one or more processors to establish the first state with the NF consumer responsive to receiving the first request, wherein the first state is established based on the request state data.

17. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the processor-executable instructions to perform the validation process with the first received policy tag from the NF consumer further cause the one or more processors to: retrieve the first stored policy tag; compare the first stored policy tag with the first received policy tag; and validate that the first stored policy tag matches the first received policy tag.

18. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein: the processor-executable instructions to process the communication based on the validation process of the first received policy tag further cause the one or more processors to establish a second state based on the communication; and the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-

readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to: generate a second policy tag, wherein the second policy tag comprises a second opaque identifier; and transmit a second communication to the NF consumer, wherein the second communication comprises second state data and the second policy tag.

19. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein the processor-executable instructions stored in the non-transitory computer-readable medium are further configured to cause the one or more processors to: receive a communication that requires an update communication from the NF consumer; generate a second policy tag comprising a second opaque identifier; and transmit, to the NF consumer, a request for the update communication, wherein: the request for the update communication comprises the second policy tag; and the second opaque identifier is different than the first opaque identifier.

20. The non-transitory computer-readable medium of claim 15, wherein: the NF consumer is selected from one of: a Policy Control Function (PCF); or a Session Management Function (SMF); and the first opaque identifier comprises a first site identifier and a first timestamp.
